

Explainer: Email

Duke OLLI Digital Explorers SIG

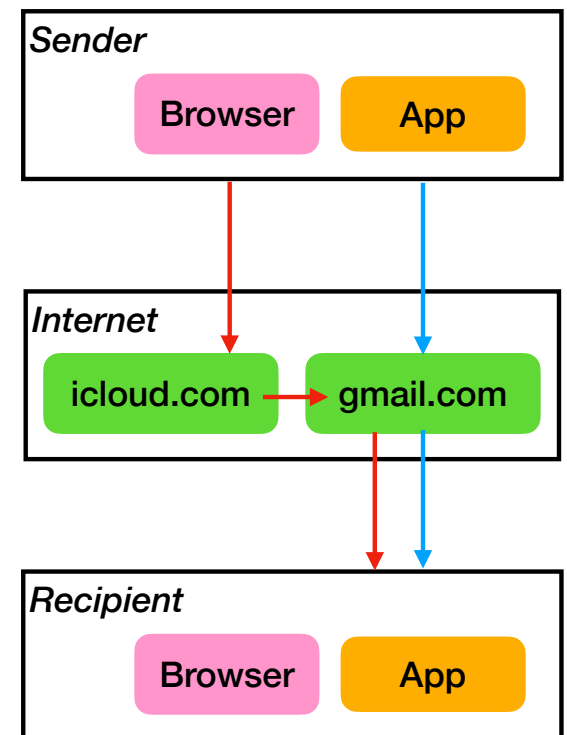
David Shamlin April 2026

Table of Contents

Topic	Page(s)
General	3 - 6
“Categories are useless.”	7
What is “archive”?	5
How do I find an email that I previously read and know I didn’t delete?	12-13
How does an email service decide what is “junk mail”?	10
Does “unsubscribe” actually do anything?	11
Do I need to routinely “clean up” my mailbox so that I don’t run out of space?	8-9
Help guide references	14

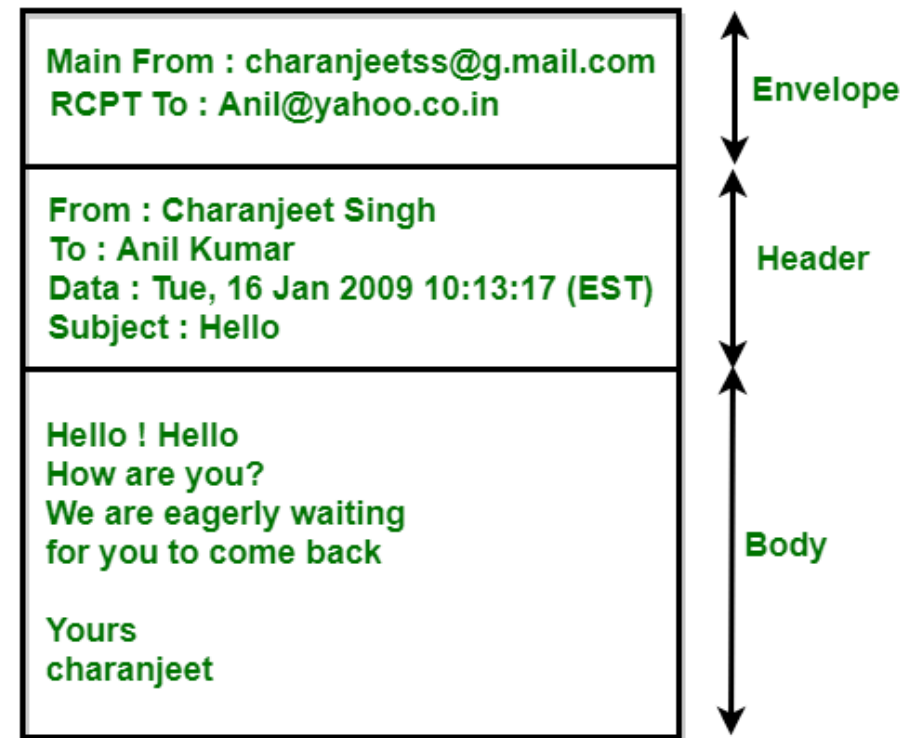
How an email message gets from the sender to the recipient

- You can access your email account either using a browser or a desktop/mobile email app. When you use a browser, you are running your email service's email web app. An email service's web app will have the same features as a desktop/mobile email app.
- Apple's mail app is called Mail. Google's mail app is called Gmail.
 - Google's mail app is only available on iPhones and iPads.
 - You can access multiple email accounts with Apple's mail app but you can only access one email account with Google's mail app.
- The red and blue arrows indicate the path an email you send to some takes as it moves across the internet.
 - The blue arrows are the path an email takes when both you and the recipient are using the *same* email service.
 - The red arrows represent the path an email takes when you are using a *different* email service than the recipient.



Email message format

- An email message is a **file** with a specific **format**. The image on the left shows the format of a basic email message
- The **envelope** contains the information needed for the email message to reach its destination (i.e., the email service of the given recipient)
- The **header** contains
 - The sender's name/email address
 - The recipients' name(s)/email address(es)
 - The subject line value
 - The date/time the email was sent
 - The date/time the email was received
 - The **return-path** is the email address an error message will be sent to if the email message cannot be delivered to the recipient(s)
- The **body** of an email message contains the text of an email message
- When an email message contains **attachments**, the attached files are included in the email message after the **body**



“Standard” folders

Most email services have the following “standard” folders.

- Inbox: emails sent to you are initially placed in either this folder or the Junk folder
- Drafts: emails you create are stored in this folder until you send them
- Sent: copies of emails you send are stored in this folder
- Junk (may alternatively be named “Spam”): the email service places emails identified as “junk” or “spam” emails in this folder
- Trash: emails you delete are placed in this folder
 - It is common for email services to have a setting that controls if/when the contents of the Trash folder is automatically deleted; this setting will likely have a “never” option if you prefer to more directly control when the Trash folder is emptied
- Archive: this folder is intended to be the storage location for emails you want to keep indefinitely but don’t need/want in your Inbox any longer.

Most email services give you the ability to create custom folders as well; custom folders can be nested. Custom folders can be used as an alternative to the Archive folder if you prefer to organize emails you retain in a more granular set of “buckets” than the Archive folder alone provides.

Adding accounts to the Apple Mail app

- The Apple Mail app allows you to access other email accounts besides your Apple iCloud email.
- You can easily add accounts you have from the following email services to your Apple Mail app:
 - Microsoft Exchange
 - Google Gmail
 - Yahoo Mail
 - AOL mail
- In the Mail app..
 - Click on **Mail > Accounts...**
 - Click on **Add Account...**
 - Click on **choose from a list**
 - Click on the name of the email service for the account you want to add
- You should then get a dialog window that allows you to enter the credentials of your email account. After you have successfully entered your email account credentials, the Mail app will remember (i.e., save) those account credentials and use them to sign you in to that account whenever you open/use the Mail app

Categories and Conversations

- Email services have two “convenience” features that organize the contents of an email folder for you.
- The **categories** feature *attempts* to identify emails into related groups like “transactions” (e.g., purchase confirmations/receipts), “promotions” (e.g., sales and special offers), “updates” (e.g., newsletters and email from social networking sites), etc.
- The **conversations** feature groups emails with related **subject** field values. E.g., an email I send to a group of people and any replies those people send back to me.
- Email services that support these features should include a setting that allows you to turn these features on and off.

Email Storage Quotas

How much storage space does my email account have?

Email accounts do have storage limits (a.k.a. **quotas** in “geek speak”); when the total size of all the emails in your account’s mailbox reaches the amount of available storage space, email messages cannot be sent or received until you reclaim some of your storage quota or you increase your quota limit.

Apple Mail and Gmail store email messages on the account’s cloud drive; these cloud drives are typically storing other types of data besides email (e.g., photos, documents, etc.).

- Apple Mail: [limited by size of iCloud Drive](#)
- Gmail: [limited by size of Google Cloud Drive](#)

Yahoo and Microsoft 365 both dedicate a fixed amount of storage for email:

- Yahoo Mail: [20GB with “free account”](#)
- Microsoft 365: [100GB per mailbox](#)

Each of these email service providers allows you to increase your email storage quota via subscription plans.

Should I routinely “clean up” my mailbox(es)?

- Yes! It is a good practice to routinely delete email messages you do not want/need to retain.
- A practice that tends to work well:
 1. Move messages in the Inbox and Sent folders that you want/need to retain to custom folders
 2. Move everything in the Drafts, Junk/Spam, and Sent folders to the Trash folder
 3. Empty the Trash folder
- The Apple Mail app has settings to control if/when the app deletes messages in the Junk/Spam and Trash folders.
 - These settings have the following options: Never, After one day, After one week, After one month, and When quitting Mail
 - To see these settings go to Mail > Settings > Accounts then select an account
- The Gmail web app client permanently deletes messages from the Trash folder after they have been in the Trash folder for 30 days

The Junk folder and Spam Filters

- Before your email service places emails sent to you in your inbox, it “scans” them to determine if they appear to be “spam” or “junk” mail.
- This feature is called a **spam filter**. A spam filter is a piece of software that uses AI-type methods—namely *pattern matching* and *heuristic analysis* (i.e., examining an email’s content for suspicious properties)—to determine if an email appears to be spam. These methods are essentially making “educated guesses”; they are not “perfect” in the sense that they will only and always identify emails that contain “junk” as “junk.” I.e., yes, sometimes an email that is not truly “junk” will get place in the Junk folder, and sometimes an email that is truly “junk” will get placed in the Inbox folder.
- Email services tend to provide a way to turn off spam filtering if that is your preference.

Emails with an “unsubscribe” link

- Many tech experts currently consider “unsubscribe” links found in the body of email messages as unreliable at best and security risks at worst. I.e., they often don’t do what they purport to do and they may lead you to a “scam site.”
- Some email clients can “auto-detect” emails of this type and present an “unsubscribe” button near an emails header when they do; the same experts who negatively criticize “unsubscribe” links, claim these buttons are a safer way to get your email addressed removed from the associated business/organization’s mail list.
- In my experience, the most effective way to keep this kind of email “noise” out of your inbox is to **block** the sender of these types of emails when you see them in your inbox.
- Emails from addresses you block will be placed in your Trash folder instead of your Inbox folder.

Suggestions for finding emails more easily

- Pick an archive strategy that makes the most sense to you: either keep all “for future reference” emails in the Archive folder or create a set of custom folders that is more granular
- Empty the Sent, Junk, and Trash folders on a routine basis
If/when you need to use the Search feature to find an email, email messages in these folders can be included in the results of a search. Keeping the contents of these folders to a minimum tends to reduce “noise” in search results.
- Turn off the “categories” feature
 - In Apple Mail app: If you see a checkmark beside the “Show Categories” item in the View menu of the Mail app, select the “Show Categories” item to remove the checkmark (indicating this feature is turned off)
 - In Gmail web app: <gear icon> > See all settings > Inbox > Categories; deselect any checkboxes that are enabled; scroll to the bottom of the page and click the “Save Changes” button
- Turn off the “conversations” feature
 - In Apple Mail app: If you see a checkmark beside the “Organize by Conversation” item in the View menu of the Mail app, select the “Organize by Conversation” item to remove the checkmark (indicating this feature is turned off)
 - In Gmail web app: <gear icon> > See all settings > General > Conversation View > Conversation view off; then scroll to the bottom of the page and click the “Save Changes” button
- Set the order in which emails are listed in a way that makes the most sense to you
 - In Apple Mail app: Select the item you prefer from View > Sort By menu item
 - In Gmail web app: *Gmail does not include a feature to sort messages in a folder*
- Use the Search feature if/when needed
See next page for links to Search help guide pages

Search feature help guide references

- Mac: [Search for emails in Mail on Mac](#)
- iPhone: [Search for email](#)
- iPad: [Search for email](#)
- iCloud: [Search, filter, and flag email in Mail on iCloud.com](#)
- Gmail
 - [Search in Gmail](#)
 - [Refine searches in Gmail](#)
 - [Gmail messages are missing](#)

References: Help Guides

- Apple Mail App
 - macOS: [Mail User Guide for macOS Tahoe](#)
 - iPad
 - [Set up mail, contacts, and calendar accounts on iPad](#)
 - [Get Started with Mail on iPad](#) (1st page of section)
 - iPhone
 - [Set up mail, contacts, and calendar accounts on iPhone](#)
 - [Add and remove email accounts on iPhone](#) (1st page of section)
- Apple Mail Web App (iCloud User Guide)
 - iCloud Mail: [What you can do with iCloud](#) (1st of there pages)
 - Use iCloud on the web: [Use Mail on iCloud](#) (1st page of section)
- Gmail: [Gmail Help](#)